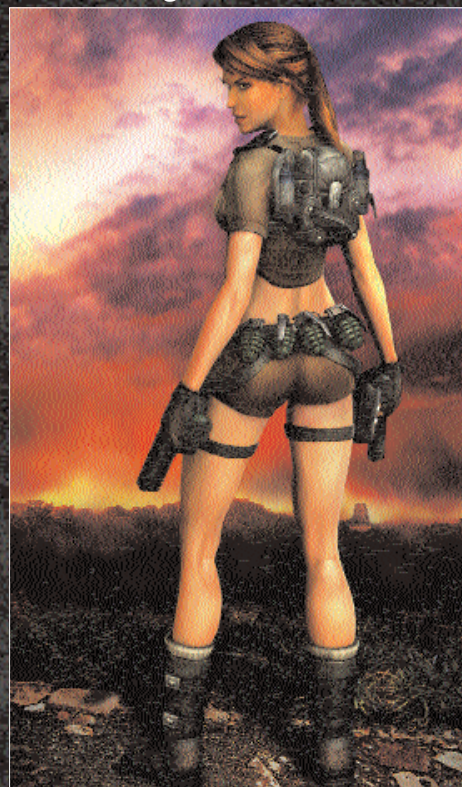
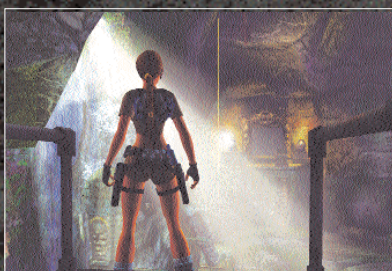




Rating: 8/10
Minimum System Requirements: Pentium 3 1.0Ghz or Athlon XP Equivalent, 256MB RAM, 64MB 3D Accelerated Card with T&L
Developer: Crystal Dynamics
Publisher: Eidos Interactive
Distributor: Milestone Interactive
Contact: sales@milestoneinteractive.com



meet a very painful end.
The Goods

In addition to her signature dual pistols, Lara can also pick up weapons that enemies leave behind. She also has a new Personal Light Source (PLS), which, while a good substitute to her older flare, is quite useless given the well lit scenes—the only time I used it was when the on-screen tutorial told me to. She also has a new magnetic grapple, which adds to the Indy Jones part of her character, letting her latch on to metal objects and swing. This very entertaining addition is tragically under-used, though. Another interesting but useless addition is the PDA which gives you a gist of your mission and what's happened so far.

The controls are quite fluid and quick leaps and moves (quite essential sometimes) can be made with minimal hair-pulling—you can even execute combinations of moves with tremendous ease. They do fall flat on their face in some of the boss fights—

most notably one where you have to holster the guns and whip out the grapple in quick succession.

Combat action is a little disappointing. While enemies gather round aplenty and keep you quite busy, it's still insultingly easy. It's a tad hard to digest that even fifteen bullets from a high-powered machine gun fail to deplete half of Lara's health.

Pretty as a picture

In the display settings, you will find an option called "Next Generation Content", which when turned on kicks up the levels of detail beyond the capabilities of most graphics cards. Our 6600 was reduced to a proud 3 fps thanks to the ultra high-resolution textures and water effects. On higher end cards like the GeForce 7 series, turning this on is definitely worth it—the game looks incredible.

That's not to say that the game doesn't look good without the next generation content—it's still quite impressive. Most noteworthy is the

attention to detail in texturing. When Lara comes out of an encounter with water, her skin is actually shiny wet and her clothes take on a slightly darker shade. She also progressively "dries" as time goes on.

Finally, Lara. Crystal Dynamics have given her a complete makeover, basing her new avatar on British model Karima Adebibe. She's prettier, curvier and is generally a more powerful stimulant for the hormones than ever before. She's also brilliantly voice-acted by actress Keely Hawes.

Endnote

For a game that generously spreads itself over 7.5 GB of hard disk space, *TRL* is horribly short. Even if you waste your time looking for all the secrets to unlock new concept art and costumes for Lara, you can't help finishing the game in a day. Overall though, the smooth gameplay, gorgeous settings and of course, Lara, make this game worth a go ■